

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Nonprofit and NGO English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For nonprofit program managers, NGO staff, grant writers, development officers, monitoring and evaluation teams, field coordinators, volunteer managers, and nonprofit executives.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Mission, Theory of Change, and Program Design

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

02 Grant Proposals and Donor Restrictions

Clarify missing information before responding.

03 Monitoring, Evaluation, and Learning

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

04 Field Operations and Partner Coordination

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

05 Safeguarding and Incident Reporting

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

06 Volunteer Management and Training

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step.

07 Advocacy, Public Messaging, and Neutrality

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

08 Board Reporting and Sustainability

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop, or use the prompts at the end of this guide.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Mission, Theory of Change, and Program Design

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

CASE

A program reports that 200 people attended workshops and calls this proof of lasting employment improvement. Follow-up outcomes have not been measured.

Teach this move

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Vocabulary to check: mission, theory of change, output, outcome.

Model response

Attendance is an output of the program. Lasting employment improvement is an outcome that needs follow-up evidence. I'll distinguish what we delivered from the change we hope to contribute to.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Second-round challenge

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Language-check answers

1. A - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed. This gives the meaning in familiar words.
2. C - How would you describe the next step in your own words? An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

05 • Conversations

1. Attendance is not lasting employment improvement - The lesson's program reports 200 workshop attendees but has not measured follow-up employment outcomes.

2. Food parcels and household stability - Separate fictional case: a community organization distributed 300 food parcels this month; no information on longer-term household stability has been collected.

3. A mentoring match is the start, not the result - Separate fictional case: a youth mentoring project has made twenty matches; meetings and participant outcomes have not yet been tracked.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Downloads recorded; use and outcomes unknown

A fictional nonprofit's budgeting guide has 500 downloads. The organization has no information on unique readers, use of the guide, or changed financial behavior. Explain the output and intended outcome without giving financial advice.

Role A: You are the program communications lead. Explain what the download count actually measures.

Role B: You are the learning officer. Ask how use and outcomes would differ from downloads.

Possible opening: Five hundred downloads show distribution activity, not five hundred confirmed changes in financial behavior.

Success checks

- Distinguish downloads, users, and outcomes.
- Explain the intended mission connection without claiming proof.
- Identify a proportionate follow-up question rather than invent a result.

Add a complication: A donor asks you to describe all downloads as people helped.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Grant Proposals and Donor Restrictions

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

A team wants to move grant money to another activity. The award's spending restrictions have not been checked.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: restricted funding, deliverable, grant proposal, mission fit.

Model response

Does the grant agreement permit this use, or is approval required? Let's confirm the restrictions with the responsible team before presenting the funds as available for the new activity.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. C - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".
2. B - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

05 • Conversations

1. Check the award before moving funds - The lesson's team proposes moving grant money to another activity, but the award restrictions have not been checked.
2. A deliverable or an illustrative example? - Separate fictional case: a draft grant proposal mentions six neighborhood sessions in one section and describes sessions as illustrative elsewhere; the application has not been submitted.

3. Unspent does not necessarily mean unrestricted - Separate fictional case: a project has an unspent travel budget and proposes buying equipment; no review of the award's budget-change conditions has occurred.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A donor offers equipment instead of cash

A fictional donor offers laptops rather than the cash requested for facilitator time. The program needs trained facilitators, and ownership, support, and any donation conditions are unknown. Hold a clarification call before accepting the offer.

Role A: You are the program lead. Explain the original need and ask how the proposed donation supports it.

Role B: You are the grants coordinator. Identify the conditions and practical responsibilities that need clarification.

Possible opening: Could we clarify the laptop donation's conditions before deciding whether it fits the program's actual need?

Success checks

- Distinguish stated donation value from mission fit.
- Ask about ownership, support, and restrictions without inventing answers.
- Agree what must be clarified before acceptance.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to accept immediately because the offer has a high stated value.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Monitoring, Evaluation, and Learning

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

Participant outcomes improved during a program, but no comparison group or alternative explanation has been examined.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: indicator, baseline, attribution, learning agenda.

Model response

The improvement is observed among participants. We cannot attribute all of it to the program from this evidence alone. I'll describe the result and the limits of the evaluation design.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. B - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. A - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 • Conversations

1. Improvement during the program is not proof of attribution - The lesson's participant outcomes improved during a program, but no comparison group or alternative explanation has been examined.
2. The follow-up respondents differ from the baseline group - Separate fictional case: eighty people completed a baseline survey, but only forty completed follow-up; average scores rose among follow-up respondents, and

nonrespondents are unexamined.

3. A changed indicator breaks the comparison - Separate fictional case: last quarter's participation indicator counted any attendance; this quarter it counts attendance at three sessions. The dashboard shows a decline.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | An unusually positive interview sample

A fictional program's success stories come from five participants selected by facilitators for strong progress. The broader participant group has not been interviewed. Discuss what the stories can illustrate and what they cannot establish.

Role A: You are the evaluation officer. Explain the limited sample and avoid generalizing its experience.

Role B: You are the fundraising manager. Ask whether the interviews demonstrate typical outcomes.

Possible opening: These interviews illustrate five selected experiences, not the typical outcome across the whole program.

Success checks

- Identify the selection method and sample limit.
- Separate illustration from a representative outcome claim.
- Agree a broader learning question without inventing an average result.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to describe the five stories as proof that the program works for everyone.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Field Operations and Partner Coordination

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

CASE

A field partner changes a planned visit date. The community contact has not yet been told and transport is still booked for the original date.

Teach this move

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

Vocabulary to check: implementing partner, field visit, contingency, community trust.

Model response

The visit date has changed, but communication and transport updates remain open. Please confirm who will contact the community and revise the booking so the handoff includes the practical consequences.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence asks for an identifiable receiving team instead of leaving responsibility with an unspecified 'someone'.

Second-round challenge

The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Language-check answers

1. A - Please confirm who will complete the outstanding check. It asks for an identifiable person or team responsible for the task.
2. C - So the result is pending and your team will follow up; is that correct? This repeats the status and responsibility and invites correction.

05 • Conversations

1. The visit date changed, but the transport did not - The lesson's implementing partner changed a field-visit date; the community contact has not been informed and transport remains booked for the original date.

2. A delivery handover with an unreadable count - Separate fictional case: a partner's delivery sheet is legible except for the quantity of teaching kits; the receiving coordinator has not counted the kits yet.

3. An interpreter request needs an acknowledged owner - Separate fictional case: a planned community consultation requires an interpreter, but neither the nonprofit nor its implementing partner has confirmed a booking.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A community contact asks for a different meeting place

For a fictional field visit, the community contact proposes moving from the school to the library. The implementing partner has not checked library availability, and the transport driver still has the school address. Agree a bounded coordination handoff.

Role A: You are the community liaison. Confirm that the venue change is a request, not an agreed booking.

Role B: You are the partner operations lead. Accept the availability check and arrange the transport update only after confirmation.

Possible opening: The library is the community contact's proposed venue, but its availability has not been confirmed.

Success checks

- Distinguish requested and confirmed venue status.
- Assign venue checking and transport communication explicitly.
- Read back the dependency before finalizing visit instructions.

Add a complication: A team member wants to tell everyone the library is booked because it was requested.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Safeguarding and Incident Reporting

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

CASE

A volunteer raises a safeguarding concern. The receiving manager must use the organization's established reporting process and handle the information carefully.

Teach this move

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Vocabulary to check: safeguarding, confidentiality, survivor-centered, incident report.

Model response

Thank you for raising the concern. I'll help route it through the safeguarding process and explain the next appropriate contact. We should share the information only through the designated channels and avoid investigating informally.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Second-round challenge

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Language-check answers

1. C - Send it no later than Thursday. 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.
2. B - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review? The requested action and information are explicit.

05 • Conversations

1. Route a concern without unnecessary circulation - In the lesson's safeguarding case, a manager discusses routing a volunteer's concern with the safeguarding focal point; no identifying details are included in this training exchange.

2. A concern sent to a shared inbox - Separate fictional case: a fictional nonprofit receives a safeguarding message in a general project inbox; the coordinator asks its designated focal point for the approved transfer route.

3. An update request without case details - Separate fictional case: a manager knows a safeguarding concern was submitted through the approved channel but has no acknowledgment reference; they ask only about receipt, not findings.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A volunteer asks for absolute secrecy

In a fictional training exercise, a volunteer asks a manager to promise absolute secrecy before sharing a safeguarding concern. The organization has a designated reporting process, but its confidentiality explanation must be consulted. Practice requesting the approved explanation without eliciting case details.

Role A: You are the manager. Ask the safeguarding focal point how to explain information handling accurately.

Role B: You are the focal point. Direct the manager to the established process and avoid giving a blanket secrecy promise.

Possible opening: Could you help me explain our reporting process accurately before I make any promise about confidentiality?

Success checks

- Use respectful language without promising absolute secrecy.
- Keep identifying details out of the practice exchange.
- Agree the approved reporting and confidentiality explanation as the next step.

Add a complication: The manager fears that admitting limits will sound uncaring.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Volunteer Management and Training

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step.

CASE

A volunteer is enthusiastic about taking on a task beyond their agreed role and training.

Teach this move

Use a specific example instead of a personality label. Explain its effect, invite the person's perspective, and agree on a practical improvement. Focus on communication that can be changed, not accent or national identity.

Vocabulary to check: volunteer role, training, supervision, duty of care.

Model response

I appreciate your willingness to help. This task needs preparation and supervision that are not part of your current role. Let's identify an appropriate task today and discuss the training needed for more responsibility.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision identifies observable work. 'Always' and a personality judgment make the feedback harder to verify or act on.

Second-round challenge

The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

Language-check answers

1. B - The last two updates omitted the agreed completion date. The recipient can check the specific examples and discuss how to improve them.
2. A - What is making this part of the task difficult? An open question may reveal a barrier the speaker has not considered.

05 • Conversations

1. Enthusiasm beyond the agreed role - Separate fictional case aligned with the lesson: a reception volunteer trained to book appointments offers to conduct eligibility interviews alone; those interviews belong to the trained program team.

2. A helpful answer that went beyond training - Separate fictional case: a reception volunteer answered a visitor's eligibility question despite being trained only to explain appointment booking; no eligibility decision is established.

3. A shift handover missing the unresolved request - Separate fictional case: a volunteer's handover omitted an unresolved accessible-appointment request, so the receiving coordinator could not follow up without asking the visitor again.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A volunteer changes the appointment order

A fictional reception volunteer rearranged appointment order to help a late arrival without consulting the supervisor. Two people then received conflicting instructions. The supervisor can consult the applicable scheduling process. Give feedback directly to the volunteer and agree what they will do next time.

Role A: You are the supervisor. Describe the observed change and its effect, then ask the volunteer to consult before changing appointment order.

Role B: You are the reception volunteer. Explain your intention, respond to the conflicting instructions, and agree a specific consultation step without making another unauthorized change.

Possible opening: Changing the appointment order without checking created conflicting instructions for two visitors.

Success checks

- Acknowledge the intention without dismissing the observed effect.
- Explain and respond to the role boundary directly.
- Have the volunteer state a specific consultation step for the next similar situation.

Add a complication: The volunteer argues that helping the late arrival justified the change, even though the other visitors were affected.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Advocacy, Public Messaging, and Neutrality

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

A fundraising draft uses an alarming statistic without its source or date. The campaign team wants to publish immediately.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: advocacy, campaign, dignity, source.

Model response

We need the source, date, and context before using this statistic. Could we verify what it measures and choose wording that accurately represents the people and situation described?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. A - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. C - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 · Conversations

1. A striking statistic without a source - The lesson's fundraising draft uses an alarming statistic with no source or date, and the campaign team wants to publish immediately.
2. A participant quotation with an uncertain permission scope - Separate fictional case: a nonprofit has a participant quotation from an internal learning interview; permission for a public advocacy campaign has not

been confirmed.

3. A campaign photograph from another year - Separate fictional case: an advocacy draft pairs a current event appeal with a clearly dated photograph from three years earlier; the caption omits the date.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | An advocacy headline turns correlation into cause

A fictional report finds that service use and school attendance rose during the same year. A campaign headline says the service caused the attendance increase. No causal analysis is supplied. Discuss a supported headline claim aloud.

Role A: You are the advocacy lead. Explain the known concurrent changes without claiming causation.

Role B: You are the campaign editor. Ask which source and scope should accompany the statement.

Possible opening: The report shows both measures rose, but it doesn't establish that our service caused the attendance increase.

Success checks

- Distinguish concurrent observations from a causal finding.
- Request the report's missing source and scope details before agreeing a final headline.
- Agree accurate spoken wording for the claim before publication review.

Add a complication: A campaign partner says the causal headline will attract more attention.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Board Reporting and Sustainability

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

CASE

A board considers using reserves or reducing program activity during a funding gap. Some funds are restricted.

Teach this move

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Vocabulary to check: board governance, cash runway, reserve, scenario.

Model response

The options have different effects on services and future flexibility. Let's distinguish unrestricted reserves from restricted funds and compare the program implications before the board makes a decision.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. 'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

Second-round challenge

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Language-check answers

1. C - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less. 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.
2. B - An increase of one percentage point. Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

05 · Conversations

1. Restricted balances are not automatically available reserves - The lesson's board considers reserves or reduced program activity during a funding gap; some funds are restricted and no detailed forecast is supplied.
2. A bridge donation that has not been pledged - Separate fictional case: a nonprofit compares maintaining four weekly sessions with reducing to two; a possible donor contribution is under discussion but not pledged.

3. A reserve-funded restart or a gradual reopening - Separate fictional case: a nonprofit considers restarting all three community groups together or reopening one first; restart costs and facilitator availability are not yet confirmed.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A lease extension during a funding gap

A fictional nonprofit can discuss a six-month office extension or moving to shared space. The shared-space fee is lower, but moving costs and suitability for confidential appointments are unassessed. Compare the options over six months for a board discussion.

Role A: You are the operations director. Identify known fees and missing operational costs.

Role B: You are the board finance chair. Ask about reserve use and the effect on service delivery.

Possible opening: The shared-space fee is lower, but we haven't included moving costs or checked whether appointments can be held appropriately.

Success checks

- Use the same six-month comparison period.
- Distinguish a lower fee from verified total savings.
- State service and cash tradeoffs and request the missing evidence.

Add a complication: A board member calls the fee difference a confirmed saving.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-28. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Adapt a partner or class activity

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Nonprofit and NGO English

Professional audience: nonprofit program managers, NGO staff, grant writers, development officers, monitoring and evaluation teams, field coordinators, volunteer managers, and nonprofit executives

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Mission, Theory of Change, and Program Design

Original fictional case: A program reports that 200 people attended workshops and calls this proof of lasting employment improvement. Follow-up outcomes have not been measured.

Language workshop: Make a complex point clear

Communication goal: Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

Language guidance: Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): In this context, ... means / The difference is that / How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Vocabulary: mission: An organization's central purpose and intended contribution. / theory of change: An explanation of how activities are expected to contribute to outcomes under stated assumptions. / output: A product or activity delivered by work, such as a report or completed session. / outcome: A change or result achieved, distinguished from the activity delivered.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Attendance is an output of the program. Lasting employment improvement is an outcome that needs follow-up evidence. I'll distinguish what we delivered from the change we hope to contribute to.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Adapt this material for a teaching session

1. Ask me one brief planning question covering learner support needs, group size and available time. Offer a default of two B2 learners and 20 minutes. Stop and wait; use the default only if I choose it.
2. Create a timed plan using the supplied case or dialogue, its actual terminology and one narrow language goal. Include an individual first attempt, partner exchange, focused feedback and a retry. Keep the total within the time I choose. State what the learner should be able to communicate at the end.
3. Provide separate role cards for two or three professional speakers. Each card needs an objective, known information and one question to resolve. Label any invented private information as a variation; do not contradict shared facts. Do not place the model answer on the learner cards.
4. Add a B1 support option with useful frames, a B2 independent task and a C1 extension involving a plausible competing constraint. Maintain the same professional meaning across levels. Explain unfamiliar terms without removing the field's normal language. Include a workable solo alternative.
5. Put teacher notes and suggested responses in a clearly separate section after the learner material. Include likely misunderstandings and a short observation checklist for facts, clarity, tone and next step. Accept multiple successful formulations. Finish with one exit question and a delayed-recall task; identify what the teacher should check before use.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Adjust tone and register

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Nonprofit and NGO English

Professional audience: nonprofit program managers, NGO staff, grant writers, development officers, monitoring and evaluation teams, field coordinators, volunteer managers, and nonprofit executives

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Mission, Theory of Change, and Program Design

Original fictional case: A program reports that 200 people attended workshops and calls this proof of lasting employment improvement. Follow-up outcomes have not been measured.

Language workshop: Make a complex point clear

Communication goal: Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

Language guidance: Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): In this context, ... means ... / The difference is that ... / How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Vocabulary: mission: An organization's central purpose and intended contribution. / theory of change: An explanation of how activities are expected to contribute to outcomes under stated assumptions. / output: A product or activity delivered by work, such as a report or completed session. / outcome: A change or result achieved, distinguished from the activity delivered.

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Optional second-round challenge: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Attendance is an output of the program. Lasting employment improvement is an outcome that needs follow-up evidence. I'll distinguish what we delivered from the change we hope to contribute to.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Match the language to the listener

1. Choose a short message or utterance from the reference and quote it exactly. Identify its purpose and likely audience. Ask me to choose a new audience: a close colleague, a decision-maker, or an external reader who may not know the jargon. Stop and wait.
2. Ask me to adapt that message for the chosen reader, keeping its facts and degree of certainty unchanged. Offer a short frame only if I request help. Wait for my attempt before showing alternatives.
3. Discuss at most three choices in my version: directness, specialist vocabulary and interpersonal tone. Explain when a direct request is clearer than extra politeness, and when an unfamiliar abbreviation needs expansion. Avoid cultural stereotypes or claims that one nationality always communicates a certain way.
4. Show two natural alternatives, such as a concise spoken version and a more explicit written version. Explain the tradeoff in each. Do not turn a request into an order, a possibility into a promise, or a pending decision into approval.
5. Ask me to respond to one realistic follow-up from the new reader, then wait. Finish by asking me to adapt the message for a second audience without losing its core meaning. Give feedback only after the attempt.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level